anda Ngozi Adichie among her favourites. "I still think of myself as a reader first and then a writer," she says.

But such is Twinkle's dedication that, in 2022, she packed her bags and left for a Master's in Fiction Writing at Goldsmiths, London. She wrapped up her course a few months ago, with an 'exceptional distinction' for her final dissertation. It was a pandemic-induced decision. "I decided to do two online writing courses at Oxford, and then I realised how much I valued the insights and the feeling of being submerged in the world of writing. It made sense to go ahead and do my Masters," she says. On the benefits of the programme, she says, "You can't teach someone to write or shape their perspective on the world, which is what makes one's writing unique. But an academic structure does provide a framework and a deeper understanding of the craft."

The family has been supportive of her literary endeavours, leaving her alone most mornings and on vacation, besides serving as a sounding board. Now that the book is out, Twinkle has more time to focus on her digital media company, Tweak, and her production house. Her columns, which had become intermittent during the Masters, will be more regular. And, yes—in her words—"those notes in my file, I am opening them again because there is one story that has started producing a racket in my head now." ■

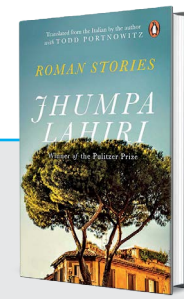
**Amit Dixit**

# SOUND OF SILENCE

In **Jhumpa Lahiri**'s *Roman Stories*, the silences are as evocative as what is articulated

I have not, in the past, been a fan of Jhumpa Lahiri's writing. But something shifted for me when I read the short stories in *Unaccustomed Earth* (2008). The melancholia that coloured the collection stayed with me for longer than I expected. Lahiri's mastery lies in what she does not say, in the emotions she does not describe, in the cataclysms that she alludes to. I believe that she is a celebrant of silence. Like many other readers and writers, I was intrigued by her decision, about a decade ago, to write in a language that she learned as an adult, carefully and conscientiously and with no external compulsion. It seemed to me that this was the most challenging of all the existential choices that a writer could make, to forego a natural intimacy of a first language and linguistic culture and seek the capacity to express oneself creatively in a tongue hitherto both alien and distant. Then, Lahiri started "self-translating" her Italian work into English. And I wondered, again, about the silences that she might be exploring. Were they, this time, the silences between languages themselves?

*Roman Stories* carries all of Lahiri's familiar virtuosity—the weightless prose, the gossamer webs that create relationships (even uncomfortable ones), the dislocated protagonists, the unspoken anguish that seeps through the self after the loss of people and places. The stories are firmly rooted in our fraught and fractured present and still, all roads lead to Rome. Rome, ever the great cosmopolis, draws the world to herself. The frictions and fissures that erupt when the native and the outsider rub up against each other lie at the heart of these stories where the protagonists, typically, are neither named nor described. Nonetheless, we feel their discomfort in the world they must share with each other.




**ROMAN STORIES**
*By Jhumpa Lahiri*
PENGUIN
**₹499; 224** pages

**Love, lust, fear, disdain, prejudice, xenophobia, anxiety, poverty, alienation—all haunt these narratives, mostly as shades and spectres**

Love, lust, fear, disdain, prejudice, xenophobia, anxiety, poverty, alienation—all haunt these narratives, mostly as shades and spectres. Every now and then, they become embodied to perpetrate an act of violence or a transgression so inevitable that it feels mundane.

Lahiri can make you feel simultaneously present in and absent from the stories that she is telling. Here, I felt disengaged, almost, as I waited for the shard of glass to pierce my skin (see 'The Steps'). For that reason, I was more persuaded by the stories that are told in the first person. These gave me a point of view in which I could be anchored, eyes through which I could see the world that the character saw, heart to feel what the character felt, the thin skin that prickled with real and imagined slights and slurs.

Lahiri compels us, in *Roman Stories*, with the dislocated and alienated selves that she creates for her characters. Some are insiders and some are outsiders but neither is comfortable with the other, neither is comfortable with the self. This is a book of sadness, of course, but the flashes of anger and bitterness in the stories illuminate a less tender emotional landscape than the one that we are accustomed to from Lahiri. Perhaps writing in Italian has allowed her to see the lightning as well as hear the thunder. ■

**Arshia Sattar**